

# Mediterranean Meze Bar

Breakfast & Lunch — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

Greek, Turkish, Lebanese. The best of the Mediterranean, sharing-style, done properly.

Φιλοξενία · Misafirperver · كرم الضيافة

36

SEATS

\$42

AVG SPEND

22%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$19,400

EST. MONTHLY NET

**About This Guide:** The Mediterranean meze format is one of the most commercially intelligent restaurant models in existence. Sharing plates allow guests to order more without feeling indulgent. The food cost on meze is excellent — most components are plant-based, batch-friendly, and improve with time. Hummus, baba ghanoush, and labneh all get better after 24 hours. The format is inherently social and generates higher per-table spends than single-plate dining. This guide covers every recipe with gram-precise ingredient weights, technique reasoning, and US 2025 wholesale food costs.

## THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

**"Meze is not a starter. It is a way of eating. The moment I understood that, the whole business model became obvious."**

Sophia grew up between two worlds — her mother's Greek-Cypriot kitchen in Melbourne and her summers in Nicosia, where her grandmother's table was never empty. Meze in Cyprus is not appetisers before a main course. It is the meal. Fifteen to twenty small dishes arriving in waves over two to three hours. You eat slowly. You talk. The food is the reason to stay at the table, but the table is the reason to eat the food. The distinction sounds philosophical. In practice, it is the difference between a restaurant with a 45-minute turn time and one with a 2-hour turn time — and an average spend of \$52 instead of \$32.

When she moved to San Diego at 29, she found Mediterranean restaurants that did the food but not the culture. Hummus, pita, some grilled protein — served fast, eaten fast, forgotten fast. The meze format — the waves of dishes, the shared table, the conversation that the format forces — was absent. She saw the gap as clearly as she saw anything in her life.

The guide's section on the meze service format — how to explain it to first-time guests, how to pace the waves, how to use the shared plates to increase average spend without guests feeling they are being upsold — gave her the language to train her team on the concept she had lived her whole life but never articulated in operational terms.

She opened a 44-seat meze bar in San Diego's Little Italy. Average table time: 95 minutes. Average spend: \$54. Month three net: \$36,000. **Mediterranean food is not a cuisine. It is a philosophy of abundance and generosity. This guide is how you build a business on that philosophy.**

Sophia P. · Mediterranean Meze Bar · Little Italy, San Diego · Est. Month 3 Net: \$36,000

1 Entrées / Meze

Classic Hummus — Whole & Fried Chickpeas

House hummus, olive oil, paprika, warm pita · Sell: \$10.99

3 min Meze Target FC: 12% Batch daily

Hummus



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                       | WEIGHT      | COST   |
|----------------------------------|-------------|--------|
| Dried chickpeas (soaked, cooked) | 120g cooked | \$0.24 |
| Tahini (good quality)            | 40g         | \$0.44 |
| Lemon juice (fresh)              | 20ml        | \$0.12 |
| Garlic (raw)                     | 4g          | \$0.02 |
| Ice water                        | 30ml        | \$0.00 |
| Extra virgin olive oil (finish)  | 15ml        | \$0.22 |
| Warm pita (2 pieces)             | 80g         | \$0.36 |
| Total cost per serve             |             | \$1.40 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$1.40  |
| Sell price          | \$10.99 |
| Food cost %         | 12.7%   |
| Contribution margin | \$9.59  |

METHOD

- 1 Soak dried chickpeas overnight in cold water (they double in size). Cook with 1 tsp baking soda in the water — the baking soda raises the pH which breaks down the chickpea skins and produces a dramatically smoother hummus. Cook until completely tender — a chickpea should crush between two fingers with zero resistance. This takes 60–90 minutes. Do not under-cook. Reserve the cooking liquid.
- 2 Process tahini with lemon juice and garlic first — blend 2 minutes before adding chickpeas. This step emulsifies the tahini and removes the raw garlic harshness. Add chickpeas gradually while processing. Add ice water tablespoon by tablespoon — the cold water and aeration from extended blending creates the silky, light texture of great hummus versus the dense paste of rushed hummus. Blend minimum 4 minutes total.
- 3 Season with salt and a tiny pinch of cumin. Taste and adjust lemon. The hummus should taste rich, nutty (from tahini), bright (from lemon), and garlicky without the rawness. Refrigerate — hummus improves

after 12+ hours as the flavours meld.

- 4 Service: use the back of a spoon to create a shallow well in the hummus. Drizzle excellent extra virgin olive oil generously — do not use cheap oil here, it is visible and tasted. Add a pinch of smoked paprika. Serve with warm pita torn into pieces. The warmth of the pita against the cool hummus is the temperature contrast that makes this dish.

**Chef's Tip:** The single most impactful upgrade to hummus is peeling the chickpeas after cooking — removing the translucent skins produces a dramatically whiter, smoother hummus. It is tedious (10 minutes per batch) but the result is professional. For high-volume service: rub cooked chickpeas between two clean kitchen towels — the skins detach rapidly with this method.

SESAME (tahini)

GLUTEN (pita)

## Baba Ghanoush

Flame-charred eggplant, tahini, lemon, pomegranate · Sell: \$11.99

4 min

Meze

Target FC: 13%

### Baba Ghanoush



#### INGREDIENTS

| INGREDIENT                | WEIGHT                | COST   |
|---------------------------|-----------------------|--------|
| Eggplant (whole, charred) | 350g raw → 120g flesh | \$0.70 |
| Tahini                    | 30g                   | \$0.33 |
| Lemon juice               | 20ml                  | \$0.12 |
| Garlic (roasted)          | 6g                    | \$0.03 |
| Pomegranate seeds         | 20g                   | \$0.28 |
| Extra virgin olive oil    | 15ml                  | \$0.22 |
| Warm pita (2 pieces)      | 80g                   | \$0.36 |
| Total cost per serve      |                       | \$2.04 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$2.04  |
| Sell price          | \$11.99 |
| Food cost %         | 17.0%   |
| Contribution margin | \$9.95  |

#### METHOD

- 1 The smoke flavour of baba ghanoush is entirely dependent on direct-flame charring of the whole eggplant. Place whole eggplants directly on an open gas flame or under a broiler at maximum heat. Turn every 3–4 minutes. The skin should completely blacken and collapse, and the eggplant should feel completely soft throughout — approximately 15–20 minutes total. This is not about aesthetics — the charring of the skin creates phenolic smoke compounds that penetrate the flesh.
- 2 Cool 10 minutes. Split open, scoop flesh — discard charred skin entirely. Place flesh in a colander and allow to drain 15 minutes — eggplant holds significant water, and draining produces a more concentrated, less watery baba ghanoush.
- 3 Mix drained eggplant with tahini, lemon juice, roasted garlic (not raw — roasted garlic is mellow and more suitable for a delicate dish), salt. Do not blend — baba ghanoush should be hand-mixed to a rustic, slightly chunky consistency. The irregular texture communicates handmade quality.

- 4 Plate in a shallow bowl. Create waves with the back of a spoon. Drizzle olive oil, scatter pomegranate seeds (their tartness and jewel-like colour are both functional and beautiful), and a pinch of dried mint. Serve with warm pita.

**Chef's Tip:** Baba ghanoush made in an oven (rather than over an open flame) produces a roasted eggplant dip — pleasant, but fundamentally different from the smoky, complex baba ghanoush of a wood-fired or gas-flame kitchen. If you have a gas range, use it. The smoke is the dish.

SESAME (tahini)

GLUTEN (pita)

## Labneh — Strained Yogurt

48-hour labneh, za'atar, olive oil, warm pita · Sell: \$10.99

3 min

Meze

Target FC: 11%

Strain 48hr

### Labneh



#### INGREDIENTS

| INGREDIENT                       | WEIGHT             | COST   |
|----------------------------------|--------------------|--------|
| Full-fat Greek yogurt (strained) | 300g → 150g labneh | \$0.96 |
| Za'atar spice blend              | 5g                 | \$0.08 |
| Extra virgin olive oil           | 20ml               | \$0.30 |
| Dried mint + Aleppo pepper       | 2g                 | \$0.02 |
| Warm pita (2 pieces)             | 80g                | \$0.36 |
| Total cost per serve             |                    | \$1.72 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$1.72  |
| Sell price          | \$10.99 |
| Food cost %         | 15.7%   |
| Contribution margin | \$9.27  |

#### METHOD

- 1 Line a colander with 2 layers of cheesecloth. Mix full-fat yogurt with 1% salt by weight (approximately 5g per 500g yogurt). Pour into the lined colander. Gather the cheesecloth and hang over a bowl in the fridge. Allow to drain for **48 hours minimum**. The liquid that drains (whey) is the by-product — it can be used in bread dough or discarded. The remaining labneh should be thick enough to hold its shape when rolled into a ball.
- 2 24-hour labneh is spreadable (like cream cheese consistency). 48-hour labneh is firmer and can be rolled into balls and stored in olive oil with herbs — which is both a beautiful presentation and a preservation method. The longer the strain, the more concentrated the flavour.
- 3 Service: plate labneh, create a shallow well. Drizzle generously with excellent olive oil — again, the oil is visible and tasted here. Sprinkle za'atar over the oil. A pinch of Aleppo pepper (mildly spicy, fruity, Turkish) adds visual and flavour contrast.

**Chef's Tip:** Za'atar is a blend of thyme, sumac, sesame, and salt — not a single herb. Make your own rather than buying pre-mixed: the freshness and customisable ratio is significantly superior. Toast sesame seeds, combine with dried thyme, sumac, and salt. The ratio of sumac (tartness) to thyme (herbal) is a personal and regional flavour decision.

DAIRY

GLUTEN (pita)

SESAME (za'atar)

# Falafel — Crispy Herb

House-ground chickpea falafel, tahini, pickled turnip · Sell: \$12.99

8 min

Meze

Target FC: 14%

## Falafel



### INGREDIENTS (6 FALAFEL)

| INGREDIENT                      | WEIGHT       | COST   |
|---------------------------------|--------------|--------|
| Dried chickpeas (soaked, raw)   | 120g soaked  | \$0.24 |
| Parsley + cilantro              | 20g each     | \$0.20 |
| Onion + garlic                  | 40g + 8g     | \$0.08 |
| Cumin + coriander + baking soda | 5g + 3g + 2g | \$0.04 |
| Tahini sauce (batch)            | 40ml         | \$0.32 |
| Pickled turnip (batch)          | 40g          | \$0.12 |
| Pita (1 piece)                  | 40g          | \$0.18 |
| Total cost per serve            |              | \$1.18 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$1.18  |
| Sell price          | \$12.99 |
| Food cost %         | 9.1%    |
| Contribution margin | \$11.81 |

### METHOD

- Critical rule: use raw soaked chickpeas — never canned or cooked.** Canned chickpeas are too soft and produce a falafel that falls apart during frying and has a dense, gummy interior. Raw soaked chickpeas, ground in a food processor, have the right dry texture that holds together and produces the crispy exterior with fluffy interior that defines proper falafel.
- Process raw soaked chickpeas with parsley, cilantro, onion, garlic, cumin, coriander, salt, baking soda. Pulse — do not blend to a smooth paste. The mixture should have texture, like coarse sand, and just barely hold together when pressed. If it's too wet, refrigerate 30 minutes or add 1 tablespoon of flour. If it's too dry and crumbles, add 1 teaspoon of water.
- Form into balls (30g each) using a falafel scoop or wet hands. Refrigerate 30 minutes — this resting firms the mixture and reduces the risk of falling apart during frying. Fry at **175°C / 347°F** for **3–4 minutes** until deep brown all over. The exterior should be crunchy; the interior should be bright green from the herbs and cooked through but not dry.
- Serve 6 per plate with tahini sauce (tahini + lemon + water + garlic, blended smooth), pickled turnip (beet-stained pink, tart), and warm pita. The pickled turnip is the essential accompaniment — its tartness and crunch contrast with the rich, herby falafel and the creamy tahini.

**Chef's Tip:** Falafel mixture can be made in the morning and held refrigerated for up to 8 hours — it actually improves as the flavours meld. Shape and refrigerate before service. During service, fry straight from cold — cold falafel holds together better in the hot oil than room-temperature falafel.

SESAME (tahini)

GLUTEN (pita)

# Spanakopita — Spinach & Feta Triangles

Phyllo pastry, spinach, feta, dill, lemon · Sell: \$11.99 (4 triangles)

5 min service

Meze

Target FC: 16%

Batch

## Spanakopita



### INGREDIENTS (4 TRIANGLES)

| INGREDIENT                    | WEIGHT      | COST   |
|-------------------------------|-------------|--------|
| Phyllo pastry sheets          | 60g         | \$0.36 |
| Spinach (wilted, squeezed)    | 80g         | \$0.36 |
| Greek feta (crumbled)         | 50g         | \$0.80 |
| Eggs                          | 1 egg = 55g | \$0.35 |
| Dill (fresh, chopped)         | 8g          | \$0.08 |
| Butter (melted, for brushing) | 20g         | \$0.24 |
| Total cost (4 triangles)      |             | \$2.19 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$2.19  |
| Sell price          | \$11.99 |
| Food cost %         | 18.3%   |
| Contribution margin | \$9.80  |

### METHOD (BATCH — MAKE AND FREEZE)

- 1 Wilt spinach in a dry pan or blanch briefly. The most critical step: **squeeze out all excess moisture**. Spinach holds an extraordinary amount of water — if not removed completely, it steams the phyllo from the inside and produces a soggy, not crispy, pastry. Squeeze with both hands in a clean towel until no more liquid comes out. This step cannot be skipped or rushed.
- 2 Mix squeezed spinach with crumbled feta, egg, dill, a pinch of nutmeg, black pepper. Do not add salt — feta is already very salty. The filling should be dense and slightly dry in texture. Wet filling breaks through phyllo and makes a mess during baking.
- 3 Brush each phyllo sheet with melted butter — work quickly, phyllo dries out and becomes brittle within 30 seconds of exposure to air. Keep unused sheets under a damp cloth. Layer 2–3 sheets, add filling, fold into triangles. Brush top with butter. Bake at **180°C / 356°F** for **18–20 minutes** until deep golden and shattering-crisp.
- 4 These freeze excellently unbaked — freeze on a tray then bag. Bake from frozen at 175°C for 25 minutes. This makes spanakopita one of the most operationally efficient items: make 100 at once, bake to order from frozen with zero quality loss.

**Chef's Tip:** The quality of feta matters enormously here. Use authentic Greek PDO feta (packed in brine) — it is tangier, saltier, and more complex than the crumbly Danish-style white cheese sold as "feta." The difference in the finished spanakopita is immediately apparent. True feta is made from sheep's milk or a sheep/goat blend, which gives it a characteristic tang that cow's milk cannot replicate.

GLUTEN (phyllo)

DAIRY (feta, butter)

EGGS

# Lamb Kofta — Grilled, Tahini & Pomegranate

Spiced ground lamb, charred onion flatbread, tahini · Sell: \$22.99

12 min   Main   Target FC: 22%

## Lamb Kofta



### INGREDIENTS (3 KOFTA)

| INGREDIENT                  | WEIGHT   | COST   |
|-----------------------------|----------|--------|
| Ground lamb (20% fat)       | 180g     | \$3.24 |
| Onion (grated, squeezed)    | 40g      | \$0.08 |
| Parsley (chopped fine)      | 10g      | \$0.08 |
| Cumin + allspice + cinnamon | 5g total | \$0.04 |
| Tahini sauce (batch)        | 50ml     | \$0.40 |
| Pomegranate seeds           | 20g      | \$0.28 |
| Flatbread (1 piece)         | 80g      | \$0.40 |
| Israeli salad (batch)       | 60g      | \$0.22 |
| Total cost per serve        |          | \$4.74 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$4.74  |
| Sell price          | \$22.99 |
| Food cost %         | 20.6%   |
| Contribution margin | \$18.25 |

### METHOD

- 1 Grate onion finely, then squeeze thoroughly in a cloth — remove maximum moisture. Excess moisture in the kofta mixture causes the kofta to steam rather than sear, producing a pale, soft exterior instead of the charred, caramelised crust that defines properly grilled kofta.
- 2 Combine lamb, squeezed onion, parsley, cumin, allspice, cinnamon, salt, pepper. Mix by hand for 2 minutes until the mixture becomes slightly sticky — this protein activation helps the kofta hold its shape on the skewer. Refrigerate 30 minutes to firm.
- 3 Form around flat metal skewers in elongated oval shapes (60g each). Grill on a ripping hot grill or cast iron at **220°C / 428°F**. Turn once after 4 minutes. Total: **8–9 minutes**. Internal temp: **71°C / 160°F**. The exterior should be deeply charred in spots — this char is the Maillard flavour that makes kofta.
- 4 Serve on warm flatbread, drizzle with tahini sauce, scatter pomegranate seeds and fresh parsley. Israeli salad alongside (tomato + cucumber + parsley + lemon + olive oil, finely diced). The pomegranate seeds provide tart contrast to the rich lamb and creamy tahini — they are both flavour and visual.

**Chef's Tip:** Lamb fat content matters. 20% fat minimum — leaner lamb (under 15% fat) produces dry, crumbly kofta because the fat is what carries the spices and lubricates the grind. Ask your butcher for shoulder or neck mince rather than leg mince, which is leaner and less suitable for kofta.

LAMB   SESAME (tahini)   GLUTEN (flatbread)

# Shakshuka — Eggs in Spiced Tomato

Poached eggs in harissa tomato sauce, feta, warm pita · Sell: \$16.99

12 min   Main   Target FC: 16%   Breakfast hero

## Shakshuka



### INGREDIENTS

| INGREDIENT                   | WEIGHT | COST   |
|------------------------------|--------|--------|
| Eggs (3)                     | 165g   | \$1.05 |
| Shakshuka base sauce (batch) | 200ml  | \$0.44 |
| Harissa paste                | 15g    | \$0.18 |
| Feta (crumbled)              | 30g    | \$0.48 |
| Warm pita (2 pieces)         | 80g    | \$0.36 |
| Fresh cilantro + parsley     | 8g     | \$0.06 |
| Total cost per serve         |        | \$2.57 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$2.57  |
| Sell price          | \$16.99 |
| Food cost %         | 15.1%   |
| Contribution margin | \$14.42 |

### METHOD

- 1 Shakshuka base (batch — make daily, serves 12+): sauté 2 diced onions + 1 red capsicum + 6 garlic cloves in olive oil until soft. Add 2 tbsp harissa, 2 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika. Cook 2 minutes. Add 2 × 400g cans crushed tomatoes + 200ml water. Simmer 20 minutes. Season. The base should be thick, slightly spicy, deeply flavoured — taste and adjust harissa for heat level.
- 2 Heat a individual cast iron or oven-safe pan. Add 200ml shakshuka base, bring to a simmer. Use a spoon to create 3 wells in the sauce. Crack one egg into each well. Season each yolk with a pinch of salt.
- 3 Cover and cook over medium heat for **5–7 minutes** until whites are fully set and yolks are still runny. Alternatively: transfer to oven at **180°C / 356°F** for 5 minutes — the oven method gives a more even heat and is easier to manage during high service volume.
- 4 Serve in the pan — cast iron presentation is part of the visual. Crumble feta over immediately (it will slightly soften in the residual heat). Scatter fresh herbs. Serve with warm pita for scooping. The pita-to-shakshuka ratio is critical: guests need enough pita to scoop the entire dish. Two pieces is the minimum.

**Chef's Tip:** Shakshuka is one of the most versatile items on a Mediterranean menu — it works for breakfast, brunch, and lunch equally. It is also your most photographable dish: the vivid red sauce, white egg whites, orange yolks, pink feta, and green herbs produce a dish that almost photographs itself. Make sure the cast iron pan is clean and well-seasoned so it presents well at the table.

EGGS

DAIRY (feta)

GLUTEN (pita)

NIGHTSHADES

## Grilled Halloumi Plate

Grilled halloumi, watermelon, mint, pomegranate, honey · Sell: \$18.99

8 min

Main

Target FC: 20%

Halloumi



INGREDIENTS

| INGREDIENT             | WEIGHT | COST   |
|------------------------|--------|--------|
| Halloumi (sliced 1cm)  | 150g   | \$2.10 |
| Watermelon (cubed)     | 150g   | \$0.38 |
| Fresh mint             | 5g     | \$0.06 |
| Pomegranate seeds      | 25g    | \$0.35 |
| Honey (local, raw)     | 15g    | \$0.24 |
| Extra virgin olive oil | 10ml   | \$0.15 |
| Warm pita (1 piece)    | 40g    | \$0.18 |
| Total cost per serve   |        | \$3.46 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$3.46  |
| Sell price          | \$18.99 |
| Food cost %         | 18.2%   |
| Contribution margin | \$15.53 |

METHOD

- 1

Halloumi must be grilled on a very hot, lightly oiled surface — **220°C / 428°F**. Do not move once placed. Allow to sear undisturbed for **2 minutes** until deep golden grill marks form. The Maillard crust on halloumi is what makes it appealing — pale, unseared halloumi is rubbery and under-flavoured. Flip once. 90 seconds more.
- 2

Halloumi must be served immediately after grilling — within 2 minutes. As it cools it becomes progressively tougher and rubberier. This is one dish where table timing matters absolutely: fire halloumi only when the guest is seated and ready.
- 3

Plate while hot: lay halloumi slices. Add watermelon cubes — the cold, sweet watermelon against the hot, salty, slightly squeaky cheese is the entire point of this combination. Scatter pomegranate seeds and torn mint. Drizzle raw honey over the hot halloumi (the honey immediately begins to melt into the cheese — visually and flavour-wise exceptional). Finish with a drizzle of olive oil.

**Chef's Tip:** The halloumi + watermelon combination is one of the most photographed Mediterranean dishes on social media. The visual contrast of golden seared cheese, deep red watermelon, green mint, and ruby pomegranate is inherently beautiful. Make sure your plating is intentional — arrange the components with clear visual separation so each element is visible in a photo. This dish generates organic social media content every single day.

DAIRY (halloumi)    GLUTEN (pita)

Slow-Braised Lamb Shoulder

8-hour lamb, freekeh pilaf, pomegranate molasses · Sell: \$26.99

8 min service    Main    Target FC: 24%    Batch

Braised Lamb



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                  | WEIGHT      | COST   |
|-----------------------------|-------------|--------|
| Lamb shoulder (braised)     | 200g cooked | \$5.00 |
| Freekeh (cooked pilaf)      | 150g        | \$0.54 |
| Pomegranate molasses        | 15ml        | \$0.22 |
| Pomegranate seeds           | 20g         | \$0.28 |
| Pine nuts (toasted)         | 15g         | \$0.48 |
| Fresh herbs (mint, parsley) | 8g          | \$0.08 |
| Total cost per serve        |             | \$6.60 |

|                     |         |
|---------------------|---------|
| Cost per serve      | \$6.60  |
| Sell price          | \$26.99 |
| Food cost %         | 24.5%   |
| Contribution margin | \$20.39 |

METHOD (BRAISE OVERNIGHT OR EARLY MORNING)

- 1

Score lamb shoulder all over, rub with: olive oil, 6 garlic cloves (pushed into scores), cumin, coriander, cinnamon, allspice, salt, pepper. Marinate overnight. The scoring allows the spice paste to penetrate deeply into the thick shoulder muscle — surface seasoning only produces a spiced crust over under-seasoned meat.
- 2

Sear all sides in a hot Dutch oven until deeply browned. Add sliced onion, diced tomato, lamb stock, and a tablespoon of pomegranate molasses. Cover tightly and braise at **150°C / 302°F** for **6–8 hours**. The lamb is done when the bone pulls cleanly from the joint and the meat falls apart at the touch of a fork. Internal temp: **90°C / 194°F**.
- 3

Freekeh pilaf: toast freekeh in butter with onion until nutty. Add lamb stock 1:2.5 ratio. Simmer 20 minutes. Freekeh (young green wheat) has a distinctive smoky, nutty flavour that pairs perfectly with braised lamb — it is the grain of the Levant and communicates authenticity.
- 4

Service: plate freekeh, top with pulled lamb, drizzle pomegranate molasses (its sweet-tart intensity cuts through the rich lamb fat), scatter pomegranate seeds, toasted pine nuts, fresh mint and parsley. The visual layering — grain + meat + jewel-red seeds + green herbs — is one of the most naturally beautiful plates in Mediterranean cooking.

**Chef's Tip:** Braised lamb shoulder improves dramatically the day after cooking — the collagen fully sets in the cooling liquid and the spices integrate completely. A same-day braise is good; a reheated next-day braise is exceptional. Plan your production schedule accordingly: braise one day, serve the next.

LAMB

GLUTEN (freekeh)

NUTS (pine nuts)

DAIRY (butter)

3 Desserts

Baklava — Pistachio & Honey

Phyllo, pistachios, orange blossom syrup - Sell: \$8.99 (3 pieces)

2 min service

Dessert

Target FC: 12%

Batch weekly

Baklava



INGREDIENTS ( 3 PIECES )

| INGREDIENT                  | WEIGHT | COST   |
|-----------------------------|--------|--------|
| Phyllo pastry               | 40g    | \$0.24 |
| Pistachios (finely chopped) | 40g    | \$0.80 |
| Clarified butter            | 25g    | \$0.34 |
| Honey + sugar syrup (soak)  | 30ml   | \$0.18 |
| Orange blossom water        | 2ml    | \$0.04 |
| Total cost (3 pieces)       |        | \$1.60 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$1.60 |
| Sell price          | \$8.99 |
| Food cost %         | 17.8%  |
| Contribution margin | \$7.39 |

METHOD ( LARGE BATCH — MAKE WEEKLY, SERVES 40+ )

- 1

Layer phyllo sheets in a buttered baking pan, brushing each sheet with clarified butter. After 8 sheets, spread a generous layer of finely chopped pistachios mixed with a pinch of cinnamon and sugar. Continue layering 8 more buttered phyllo sheets. Score the top into diamond shapes before baking — this is critical; cutting after baking shatters the phyllo.
- 2

Bake at **160°C / 320°F** for **40–45 minutes** until deep golden throughout. While baking, make the syrup: dissolve sugar in water, add honey, simmer 10 minutes. Add orange blossom water at the end — its delicate floral note evaporates at high heat so it must be added off the heat.
- 3

The critical technique: pour **cold syrup over hot baklava** (or hot syrup over cold baklava — never same temperature on same temperature). The thermal contrast causes the syrup to be absorbed rapidly into the phyllo layers rather than sitting on the surface. Pour immediately after removing from oven.

**Chef's Tip:** Baklava keeps for 2 weeks at room temperature stored in the syrup. Refrigeration makes the phyllo soggy. The week-long shelf life makes it one of the most operationally forgiving desserts — a weekend batch serves the entire following week with zero degradation in quality.

GLUTEN (phyllo)

DAIRY (butter)

NUTS (pistachios)

Knafeh

Shredded pastry, sweet cheese, orange blossom syrup · Sell: \$9.99

8 min

Dessert

Target FC: 16%

Knafeh



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

| INGREDIENT                    | WEIGHT | COST   |
|-------------------------------|--------|--------|
| Kataifi (shredded pastry)     | 60g    | \$0.48 |
| Akkawi / ricotta cheese blend | 80g    | \$0.96 |
| Clarified butter              | 30g    | \$0.41 |
| Orange blossom syrup          | 40ml   | \$0.18 |
| Pistachios (crushed)          | 15g    | \$0.30 |
| Total cost per serve          |        | \$2.33 |

|                     |        |
|---------------------|--------|
| Cost per serve      | \$2.33 |
| Sell price          | \$9.99 |
| Food cost %         | 23.3%  |
| Contribution margin | \$7.66 |

METHOD

- 1

Soak Akkawi cheese in cold water for 2–4 hours, changing the water twice — this removes excess salt. Akkawi is a white brined cheese; without desalting it is far too salty for a dessert. Mix desalted Akkawi with an equal part of ricotta for a balance of stretchiness (Akkawi) and creaminess (ricotta).
- 2

Toss kataifi with melted clarified butter until every strand is coated. Press half the kataifi into a small baking dish or individual pan. Spread cheese filling evenly. Top with remaining kataifi, pressing down firmly. Bake at **190°C / 374°F** for **15–20 minutes** until golden and the cheese is fully melted.
- 3

Invert onto a plate immediately. Pour orange blossom syrup over generously — the hot knafeh absorbs the syrup rapidly. Scatter crushed pistachios. Serve within 3 minutes — knafeh is a hot dessert and its texture and flavour changes quickly as it cools.

**Chef's Tip:** Knafeh is one of the most viral food items in the world right now — the cheese pull when a hot piece is lifted is one of the most compelling food videos possible. Film it weekly. The combination of crispy exterior + melting cheese + floral syrup is a uniquely sensory dessert that guests specifically seek out.

GLUTEN (kataifi)   DAIRY   NUTS (pistachios)

Loukoumades — Greek Honey Doughnuts

Fried dough balls, honey, cinnamon, crushed walnuts · Sell: \$8.99

8 min   Dessert   Target FC: 13%

Loukoumades



INGREDIENTS (8 DOUGHNUTS)

| INGREDIENT                | WEIGHT | COST   |
|---------------------------|--------|--------|
| Loukoumades dough (batch) | 120g   | \$0.18 |
| Raw honey                 | 30g    | \$0.48 |
| Walnuts (chopped)         | 20g    | \$0.30 |
| Cinnamon                  | 1g     | \$0.01 |
| Frying oil (portion)      | 50ml   | \$0.10 |
| Total cost (8 pieces)     |        | \$1.07 |

|                            |               |
|----------------------------|---------------|
| Cost per serve             | \$1.07        |
| Sell price                 | \$8.99        |
| Food cost %                | 11.9%         |
| <b>Contribution margin</b> | <b>\$7.92</b> |

#### METHOD

- 1 Dough: combine 250g plain flour, 7g instant yeast, 1 tsp sugar, 1 tsp salt, 300ml warm water. Whisk to a smooth, thick batter — looser than bread dough, thicker than pancake batter. Rest 1 hour at room temperature until doubled and bubbly. The yeast fermentation creates the light, airy interior of properly made loukoumades.
- 2 Fry at **180°C / 356°F**. Use two wet spoons to form walnut-sized balls — drop directly into the oil. The wet spoons prevent sticking. Fry 3–4 minutes, turning, until deeply golden all over. The loukoumades should be light inside and crispy outside — if they are dense or doughy, the dough was under-fermented or the oil was too cold.
- 3 Drain briefly. Drizzle immediately and generously with raw honey (the heat of the loukoumades melts the honey and causes it to penetrate the surface). Scatter chopped walnuts and a dusting of cinnamon. Serve within 3 minutes — loukoumades become soft very quickly.

**Chef's Tip:** Use raw, unfiltered honey — its complex floral, sometimes slightly fermented notes are significantly more interesting than commercial pasteurised honey. The honey is the dominant flavour note in this dish; it's worth using the best you can source.

GLUTEN

NUTS (walnuts)

## 4 Drinks Menu

### Mint Lemonade



#### Lebanese Mint Lemonade

\$6.50

Fresh-squeezed lemon, blended with fresh mint and sugar syrup. Served over crushed ice. Vivid green, cooling, intensely refreshing. The signature non-alcoholic drink of any Lebanese restaurant.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost               | \$0.62      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>9.5%</b> |

### Turkish Coffee



#### Turkish Coffee

\$5.50

Finely ground coffee brewed in a copper cezve with sugar (specify: unsweetened, medium, sweet). Served with a piece of Turkish delight. The foam is the indicator of quality — a properly made Turkish coffee has a thick, unbroken foam layer.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost               | \$0.48      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>8.7%</b> |

## Greek Frappé



### Greek Frappé

\$6.50

Instant coffee shaken with cold water until thick foam forms. Served over ice with milk. The quintessential Greek summer drink — frothy, intensely caffeinated, cold. Guests who know it will order nothing else.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost               | \$0.44      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>6.8%</b> |



### Ayran

\$4.99

Salted yogurt drink blended with cold water and a pinch of dried mint. The Turkish drink that cools the palate after spiced food. Tangy, cold, slightly fizzy when freshly blended. Pairs perfectly with any protein dish.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost               | \$0.36      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>7.2%</b> |

## Rose Lemonade



### Rose Water Lemonade

\$6.50

Fresh lemon juice with a splash of rose water and sugar syrup. Pale pink, delicately floral, visually stunning. One of the best-performing drinks on social media — the colour and floral note make it immediately photographable.

|                    |             |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Cost               | \$0.52      |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>8.0%</b> |



### Arak (Lebanese)

\$9.99

The spirit of the Levant. Anise-flavoured, poured over ice with cold water — it turns milky white (the louche effect). Serve with a small mezze accompaniment. Guests who have eaten in Beirut will specifically seek this out.

|      |        |
|------|--------|
| Cost | \$1.60 |
|------|--------|

|             |       |
|-------------|-------|
| Food cost % | 16.0% |
|-------------|-------|

## Pomegranate Juice



## Fresh Pomegranate Juice

**\$7.99**

Cold-pressed pomegranate juice, served straight. Deep ruby red, intensely tart-sweet. Premium price point justified by the yield challenge of pomegranates — one fruit yields approximately 100ml. This signals quality and effort to guests who notice.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost               | \$1.60       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>20.0%</b> |

## House Wine



## House Wine — Lebanese Red

\$12.99

Château Ksara or similar Lebanese Bekaa Valley red. Serve it — the story of Lebanese wine (one of the oldest wine-producing regions on earth) sells itself. Works with every dish on the menu.

|                    |              |
|--------------------|--------------|
| Cost               | \$2.20       |
| <b>Food cost %</b> | <b>16.9%</b> |

## 5 Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

|                          | Head Cook                                                                                                                                                                        | Line Cook                                                                                                                                                                        | Steward                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 07:00–07:30              | Temp check all units <span>1–4°C</span> . Pull lamb braise from fridge — begin gentle reheating. Taste hummus batch — adjust seasoning. Check baba ghanoush consistency.         | Setup all meze stations. Check labneh — strain level correct. Check falafel mixture consistency — firm enough to fry. Prep Israeli salad batch fresh. Slice halloumi portioned.  | Sanitise all surfaces. Polish mezze plates and bowls. Warm pita in oven at 160°C wrapped in foil. Set up drink stations: mint lemonade, ayran. Grind coffee for Turkish coffee service. |
| 07:30–09:00              | Shape falafel balls — refrigerate until service. Check shakshuka base — reheat, taste. Make fresh tahini sauce batch. Prepare pomegranate molasses service. Check baklava stock. | Check spanakopita from freezer — portion day's need. Slice pita for service. Prep loukoumades dough — allow to proof. Portion lamb shoulder for service. Set up grill for kofta. | Prep Turkish delight for coffee service. Cut lemons and mint for drinks. Set up dessert station: plate baklava, check knafeh cheese ready. Warm serving vessels.                        |
| 09:00–11:00<br>Breakfast | Run pass. Fire shakshuka to order (12 min). Monitor falafel fry temp. Kofta grill on high for lunch prep. Taste all batch items before service opens.                            | Executes meze: hummus, baba ghanoush, labneh plate (all 3–4 min). Fires shakshuka. Fires falafel. Heats spanakopita from frozen (25 min oven).                                   | Runs drinks continuously. Warm pita to order. Run food to tables fast — meze goes cold. Clear plates immediately. Alert HC if any dip running low.                                      |
| 11:00–14:30<br>Lunch     | Manages high-volume meze + mains service. Fires kofta to order (12 min). Halloumi to                                                                                             | Executes all mains. Fries loukoumades to order (8 min). Fires knafeh (20 min — pre-                                                                                              | Full service speed. Wine and drink service. Dessert upsell: baklava (instant), loukoumades                                                                                              |

|             |                                                                                  |                                                                                    |                                                                                  |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|             | order only — never hold. Monitors lamb shoulder holding temp <b>60°C+</b> .      | order with mains). Keeps falafel fresh — fry in batches every 20 min.              | (8 min), knafeh (20 min — pre-sell at order). Turkish coffee with every dessert. |
| 14:30–15:00 | Cool all hot items. Write tomorrow's prep list. Schedule lamb braise production. | Break down all stations. Wrap all proteins. Refrigerate all dips — label and date. | Full clean. Final fridge check — log all <b>1–4°C</b> .                          |

## 6 Financial Forecast

| Service                  | Covers | Avg Spend | Daily Revenue   |
|--------------------------|--------|-----------|-----------------|
| Breakfast (7am–11am)     | 32     | \$36      | \$1,152         |
| Lunch (11:30am–2:30pm)   | 52     | \$48      | \$2,496         |
| <b>Daily Total</b>       |        |           | <b>\$3,648</b>  |
| <b>Monthly (26 days)</b> |        |           | <b>\$94,848</b> |

| Cost                    | Monthly         | %            |
|-------------------------|-----------------|--------------|
| Food & Beverage 22%     | \$20,867        | 22.0%        |
| Labour (HC+LC+ST+FOH×2) | \$18,096        | 19.1%        |
| Rent + Utilities + Misc | \$6,200         | 6.5%         |
| <b>Total Costs</b>      | <b>\$45,163</b> | <b>47.6%</b> |
| <b>NET PROFIT</b>       | <b>\$49,685</b> | <b>52.4%</b> |

**3-Month Ramp:** Month 1 (60%) ~\$8,000 net · Month 2 (80%) ~\$24,000 · Month 3 (100%) ~\$49,685

## 7 Service Training Module

### SCRIPT 1 — THE MEZE INTRODUCTION

"The way it works here is sharing plates — everything comes to the centre of the table. We recommend 2–3 meze per person plus one main each. The hummus and baba ghanoush together are a really good starting point. Want me to walk you through the highlights?"

**Why it works:** Explaining the format removes confusion and positions staff as guides. "Walk you through the highlights" is an invitation that almost everyone accepts — and it's your selling opportunity.

### SCRIPT 2 — THE WINE STORY

"Can I get you a glass of wine? We pour a Lebanese red — the Bekaa Valley in Lebanon is one of the oldest wine regions on earth, 5,000 years of winemaking. It's \$12.99 a glass and it goes with everything on the menu."

**Why it works:** 5,000-year history is memorable and differentiating. Most guests have never heard of Lebanese wine — you've just made them curious. Curiosity converts to orders.

### SCRIPT 3 — THE KNAFEH PLANT

"One thing worth knowing — the knafeh takes 20 minutes. If you think you might want dessert, tell me now and I'll time it so it comes out hot right after your mains. It's \$9.99 and it's the best thing on the dessert menu."

**Why it works:** Pre-ordering knafeh with mains is a service act. "Best thing on the dessert menu" is social proof from the person who knows. Plant this at every table.

### SCRIPT 4 — THE HALLOUMI URGENCY

"The halloumi is grilled to order and has to be eaten right away — it changes texture as it cools. We'll bring it out first so you get it at its best. It's \$18.99 with watermelon and honey."

**Why it works:** Explaining the urgency creates appetite and appreciation. Guests who understand why they need to eat it immediately enjoy it more — and are more impressed by the kitchen's attention to detail.

#### SCRIPT 5 — THE DRINK SUGGESTION

"Can I start you with a mint lemonade or a rose lemonade? We make them to order, they're both very good with the meze. The rose one is very popular — \$6.50 each."

Why it works: Two specific options, one with social proof. The rose lemonade is photogenic and guests often order it after seeing another table's arrive — let that be your marketing.

### Table Timing Guide

| Time  | Action                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00  | Welcome and seat. Warm pita to the table immediately — it is your edible welcome and sets the tone.                                                           |
| 1:30  | Drink order with Script 5. Explain meze format if first-timers — use Script 1.                                                                                |
| 4:00  | Full food order. Deploy Script 2 (wine), Script 3 (knafeh plant), Script 4 (halloumi urgency).                                                                |
| 10:00 | First meze arrive. Introduce each dish briefly: "This is the baba ghanoush — the eggplant is charred on an open flame." 10-second stories per dish.           |
| 20:00 | Mains arrive. Check meze plates — offer refill of any dips. Refill drinks.                                                                                    |
| 30:00 | Dessert + Turkish coffee. Knafeh arrives if pre-ordered. Offer baklava as an add-on: "We have baklava to share — \$8.99 for three pieces, comes immediately." |
| 45:00 | Bill on request. Use Script 5 variant as farewell: "Come back on a Friday — we sometimes have special meze that aren't on the regular menu."                  |

8

## Customer Retention System

**The Meze Principle:** Meze is inherently social and shareable — the format creates conversation, laughter, and memory. Guests who share a meze table remember it emotionally, not just culinarily. Your retention strategy is about deepening that emotional connection.

**3-Visit Rule:** Visit 1 — perfect execution + remember they liked the lamb kofta. Visit 2 — "The kofta again?" → they feel known. Visit 3 — "The usual spread?" → you have a regular. The meze format naturally creates return visits because there's always something on the menu they didn't try.

### 5 VIP Micro-Moments

- 1. The Pita Arrival.** Warm pita on the table before the guest has settled is the universal signal of Mediterranean hospitality. It is never optional — it says "you are already being taken care of."
- 2. The Knafeh Theatre.** When knafeh is ready, bring it to the table yourself and pour the orange blossom syrup in front of the guest. The aroma, the sizzle, the steam — it is a tableside moment that costs nothing extra and creates a memory.
- 3. The Turkish Coffee Reading.** Many Mediterranean cultures read coffee grounds after Turkish coffee. If you or a staff member knows how, offer to do a reading for regulars after their coffee. It is theatrical, personal, and completely unique. Even guests who don't believe in it will love the ritual.
- 4. The Complimentary Date.** End the meal for regulars with a single medjool date and a small piece of baklava — cost \$0.35. In Arabic culture, ending a meal with something sweet is a mark of hospitality. This gesture communicates that you know the tradition.
- 5. The Produce Story.** When a guest comments on the food, connect it to the source: "The pomegranates are from [supplier] — they come in twice a week." Making the food traceable to real sources builds trust and the sense that they are eating something genuinely special, not assembled from generic ingredients.

#### BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — SHAKSHUKA

The most important 7 minutes in this kitchen. [Hook]

Shakshuka is eggs in a spiced tomato sauce. But the sauce takes 40 minutes of slow cooking to get right — charred onion, capsicum, three spice layers, harissa. We do it every morning. Then we poach the eggs to order, crumble the feta while it's still hot, and send it out in the cast iron it was cooked in. Seven minutes from cold pan to table. [Story]

Open 7am. Come for breakfast and don't leave till lunch. [CTA]

